

1.1 Troubleshooting Techniques

The primary requirement for troubleshooting is to be methodical. Don't panic, don't rush. Being patient and methodical is better than being quick and sorry. Whatever the problem, the first step is to develop an understanding of what are the possible causes. Using a notepad and pencil (or pen) is helpful. First, note down the symptom. The symptom is what you see happening, not what you *think* may be happening. Once you know the symptom, the next step is to identify the possible problems that might be the cause for this symptom. Some symptoms may be caused by a single problem. Usually, you will not be so lucky. Most symptoms can be caused by one or more problems. Isolate the sub-systems (this guide covers all the major sub-systems) that may be causing the problem. Then investigate each sub-system and eliminate them from the possible problem checklist. Look at the example troubleshooting table below to give you an idea on how you can approach the exercise:

Symptom: PC powers on but there is no display			
Sub-system	Problem	Solution	Remarks
Power Supply Unit (PSU)	New video card may be overtaxing the PSU	Get new PSU or use old video card	Check the other sub-systems first
Video card	Not plugged in properly	Plug it in correctly	
Live power / Video feed	Check the power cables: the monitor to motherboard cable	Fix them properly	
RAM	RAM not plugged in properly	Set the DIMMs in firmly	
Software drivers	Software drivers not loading	Roll back to last known good or boot in safe mode and rectify	